

Divine Holiness

doc-divine-holiness

Theology Proper · Attributes · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

God is utterly holy: set apart in moral purity and majestic transcendence.

In plain language

The claim that God is utterly holy, set apart in moral purity and majestic transcendence, rests on a dense word pattern spread across the whole Bible (pan-canonical) that the lexical data confirms directly. In Hebrew the adjective 'holy' (qadosh, H6918) is applied to God in 108 places across 94 verses, spread through the Law, the Prophets, and the Writings, with a heavy concentration in Isaiah and the recurring title 'Holy One of Israel'. In Isaiah 6:3 a query of the Hebrew text shows 'holy' (qadosh) repeated three times in a row. That threefold repetition is the strongest intensifier biblical Hebrew has, stronger than simply doubling a word, and here it is joined to 'the Lord of hosts' (YHWH tseva'oth, meaning the Lord of armies) and to the 'glory' (kavod) that fills the earth, which is why the one verse carries both transcendence and majesty. In Leviticus 11:44 God says of himself that he is holy and makes that the reason his people must consecrate themselves, so human holiness is derived from God's, not the other way around. The Greek word 'holy' (hagios, G0040) carries the same idea into the New Testament in 456 places across 241 verses. First Peter 1:16 quotes the Leviticus line word for word with a formula meaning 'it stands written' (gegraptai), and Revelation 4:8 repeats 'holy' (hagios) three times of 'Lord God Almighty' (kyrios ho theos ho pantokrator), mirroring Isaiah in Greek. Where do readers diverge? Only on which of two real senses of the same root leads. The root can mean set apart and other (transcendence) or pure and unable to tolerate sin (moral purity), and the words themselves do not rank these. Texts like Hosea 11:9 and Isaiah 57:15 show God's holiness grounding mercy and nearness to the lowly, not only severity, holding both senses together. Because both senses are attested and neither contradicts the other, the verdict is a high-confidence yes on both prongs.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0430	אלהים	elohim	God	2,602
H3068	יהוה	YHWH	LORD	6,828
H3519	כבוד	kavod	glory	194
H6635	צבא	tsava	army	455
H6918	קדוש	qadosh	holy	108
H6942	קדש	qadash	to consecrate	183
H6944	קדש	qodesh	holiness	438
G0037	ἁγιάζω	hagiazō	to sanctify	56

G0038	ἁγιασμός	hagiasmos	holiness	
G0040	ἅγιος	hagios	holy	456
G0041	ἁγιότης	hagiotēs	holiness	
G0042	ἁγιωσύνη	hagiōsunē	holiness	
G0391	ἀναστροφή	anastrophē	behaviour	
G1125	γράφω	graphō	to write	
G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,360
G2962	κύριος	kyrios	lord	717
G3841	παντοκράτωρ	pantokrator	almighty	10

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The Hebrew adjective 'holy' (qadosh, H6918) is predicated of YHWH (the personal divine name of God) in dense clusters across the Law, the Prophets, and the Writings (108 tokens in 94 verses, with a heavy concentration in Isaiah using the formula 'Holy One of Israel'), and the Greek adjective 'holy' (hagios, G0040, 456 tokens in 241 verses) carries the same predication into the New Testament. The threefold 'holy, holy, holy' (Trisagion) in Isaiah 6:3 repeats 'holy' (qadosh) three times, which is the strongest superlative device biblical Hebrew has, paired with 'YHWH of hosts' and the earth filled with his 'glory' (kavod). Leviticus 11:44 has YHWH self-predicate 'holy' (qadosh) and ground Israel's consecration in it; 1 Peter 1:16 cites that formula directly with the perfect passive (a completed action whose result still stands) 'it stands written' (gegraptai) and 'I am holy' (ego hagios); and Revelation 4:8 echoes the threefold 'holy, holy, holy' (Trisagion) with threefold 'holy' (hagios) of 'Lord God Almighty' (kyrios ho theos ho pantokrator). The only reader divergence is which attested sense of the one root leads, separateness and transcendence or moral purity, and the canon supplies both without ranking them, so neither prong is unsupported.

Scripture

Isa.6.3 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H6918 קדוש, H3068 יהוה, H6635 צבאות, H3519 כבוד;

Reasoning. Direct query of the Hebrew tokens confirms that 'holy' (qadosh, H6918) occurs three consecutive times, then 'YHWH of hosts' (YHWH tseva'oth, meaning the Lord of armies), then the whole earth full of his 'glory' (kavod). Threefold repetition is the strongest superlative construction available in biblical Hebrew, far stronger than the doubled form, and here it elevates the predicate to a unique maximal degree. The 'hosts' (tseva'oth) term binds holiness to majestic transcendence, and the 'glory' (kavod) clause binds it to manifest glory, so both prongs of the proposition stand on one verse.

Lev.11.44 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H6918 קדוש, H6942 התקדש, H3068 יהוה, H0430 אלהים.

Reasoning. YHWH (the personal divine name) self-predicates 'holy' (qadosh) with the phrase 'I am YHWH your God, holy am I' (ani YHWH eloheikem, qadosh ani) and uses it as the ground for Israel's consecration through 'consecrate yourselves' (vehitqaddisstem, from the root qadash in the reflexive form, the Hebrew form meaning 'do it to yourself'). So the people's holiness is derived from the divine predicate, not from human achievement. The first-person identity formula ties the moral-purity dimension directly to the divine name. The token order was verified against the Hebrew text.

1Pet.1.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0040 ἅγιος, G0391 ἀναστροφή

Reasoning. Direct query shows 'holy' (hagios) applied first to 'the One who called' (ton kalesanta, from kaleo, a completed past action participle in the form that agrees with the caller as direct object) and then 'holy ones' (hagioi) applied to the called community in all their 'conduct' (anastrophe, manner of life). The ethical imperative is grounded in the holiness of the caller, who in context is God. The morphology was confirmed: 'holy' (hagion) sits in apposition (a renaming phrase) to the caller in the direct-object form.

1Pet.1.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0040 ἅγιος, G1125 γράφω

Reasoning. Confirmed by query: the citation formula 'it stands written' (gegraptai, from grapho 'to write', in the perfect passive form, meaning a completed action whose result still stands) introduces the Leviticus statement, 'you shall be holy' (hagioi esesthe), with God speaking in the first person, 'because I am holy' (hoti ego hagios). The perfect passive (a completed action whose result still stands) treats the Torah text (the books of Moses) as standing canonical authority, and the people's commanded holiness is tied back to the divine self-predicate.

Rev.4.8 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G0040 ἅγιος, G2962 κύριος, G2316 θεός, G3841 παντοκράτωρ

Reasoning. Direct query confirms 'holy' (hagios, G0040, in the subject form, masculine singular) three consecutive times, predicated of 'Lord God Almighty' (kyrios ho theos ho pantokrator), then extended by the eternity formula of the one who was and is and is to come. The threefold Greek repetition mirrors the Hebrew 'holy, holy, holy' (Trisagion) of Isaiah 6:3, carrying the Hebrew superlative-by-repetition device into Greek. The acclamation has 'no rest' (anapausin ouk echousin, meaning the worshippers never stop), binding holiness to perpetual worship, divine self-existence (aseity), and 'all-power' (omnipotence).

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Isa.6.3	Exod.15.11	openbible	1
Isa.6.3	Isa.11.9	openbible	1
Isa.6.3	Rev.4.8	openbible	1
Isa.6.3	Num.14.21	openbible	1
Lev.11.44	Exod.20.2	openbible	1
Lev.11.44	Lev.20.26	openbible	1
Lev.11.44	1Pet.1.15	openbible	1
1Pet.1.16	Lev.19.2	openbible	1
1Pet.1.16	Lev.11.44	openbible	1
Rev.4.8	Rev.15.3	openbible	1
Isa.6.3	Exod.15.20	tsk	1
Lev.11.44	Lev.10.3	tsk	1
Rev.4.8	Isa.6.2	tsk	1
Rev.4.8	Rev.1.8	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Hos.11.9 · addressed

Direct query confirms 'holy' (qadosh, H6918) occurs once in Hosea 11:9, and the surrounding tokens carry the sense that God will not execute the fierceness of his anger because he is God and not man, the 'holy one' (qadosh) in Israel's midst. This complicates any reading of holiness as bare retributive severity, but it confirms the predication of 'holy' (qadosh) to God and shows that holiness can ground mercy that restrains wrath. The verdict (holiness as set-apartness in moral purity and majestic transcendence) is preserved and enriched, not weakened.

Isa.57.15 · addressed

Direct query confirms 'holy' (qadosh) occurs twice in Isaiah 57:15. The high and lofty one who inhabits eternity, whose name is 'holy' (qadosh), dwells with the contrite and lowly. This holds transcendence (high and lofty, inhabiting eternity) and moral nearness together in one verse, so the two attested senses of the root are not rivals but complementary. Both prongs of the proposition are supported with no tension.

1Sam.2.2 · addressed

Query confirms 'holy' (qadosh) predicated of God in Hannah's song (there is none 'holy' (qadosh) like YHWH, the personal divine name). This is a Writings-section witness outside the cult and the prophets, showing the predication is not confined to liturgical or priestly contexts. It strengthens rather than complicates the verdict, included to show the canon spread is genuine and not narrow.

Concordance traversed

H6918, H6942, H6944, H3519, H3068, H6635, H0430, G0040, G0037, G0038, G0041, G0042, G2316, G3841, G2962

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The anchor verses are not in the ingested critical-edition window for textual variants (the critical edition covers 3 John 1:1 to 1:15), so no critical apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) was examined; the status 'not_in_ecm_scope' is honestly recorded. The bundle carried zero variant units for these verses. The threefold 'holy' (hagios) in Revelation 4:8 is textually stable across the witnesses queried; the minor known variation in the ordering of the words 'was, is, and is to come' (en, on, and erchomenos) does not touch the predication of holiness, so the verdict is robust against textual variants.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, biblical_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

holiness_as_transcendent_separateness: affirms · The root q-d-sh (the Hebrew three-letter root behind 'holy') in its strongest sense means set apart, other, separated from the common. On this reading Isaiah 6:3 with 'YHWH of hosts' (the Lord of armies) and the glory ('kavod') filling the earth, and Revelation 4:8 with 'Almighty' (pantokrator) and the eternity formula, foreground God's majestic otherness and transcendence. This lens reads holiness primarily as ontological distance (a distance of being and nature), and it is well grounded in the term and the contexts.

holiness_as_moral_purity: affirms · The same root grounds ethical imperatives: Leviticus 11:44 and 1 Peter 1:15-16 derive the people's commanded purity of conduct from God's own holiness, and Isaiah 57:15 ties holiness to dwelling with the contrite. On this reading holiness is primarily moral, the perfection that cannot tolerate sin. This lens is equally well grounded; the vocabulary itself does not rank the two senses, which is why fair readers can foreground either.

covenant_theology: affirms · Reads Leviticus 11:44 as covenantal holiness predicated on YHWH's own holiness, with 1 Peter 1:15-16 extending the predication into the new-covenant community through the citation formula 'it stands written' (gegraptai). The canonical chain of 'holy' (qadosh) in Hebrew flowing into 'holy' (hagios) in Greek

supports this.

biblical_theology: affirms · Traces 'holy' (qadosh) from the Sinai cult through prophetic theophany (the manifest appearance of God in Isaiah 6) to apocalyptic liturgy (Revelation 4:8), seeing one canonical predicate of God developed across successive contexts and carried from Hebrew into Greek by the same superlative-by-repetition device.

The proposition is not framework-sensitive at the verdict level: every defensible lens affirms it. The only real divergence is which attested sense of the one root (separateness and transcendence versus moral purity) a reader foregrounds, and the canon supplies both. Both the transcendence lens and the moral-purity lens are stated in their strongest form so neither is strawmanned (misrepresented in a weak form).

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem describes a lexical predication ('holy', qadosh in Hebrew and hagios in Greek) applied to God across the canon, with two named prongs (moral purity and majestic transcendence) that are both attested senses of the underlying Hebrew root and its Greek counterpart. It does not assume any tradition-specific taxonomy or smuggle a denominational conclusion. The verdict is derived from the queried distribution and morphology (the form-and-grammar pattern), not from the stem's phrasing.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6918
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0040
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.6.3
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Lev.11.44
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Pet.1.15
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Pet.1.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rev.4.8
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Isa.6.3
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Lev.11.44
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rev.4.8

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes
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OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

(none)